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UNHCR SECUNDARIA

Background

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Introduction to the committee:

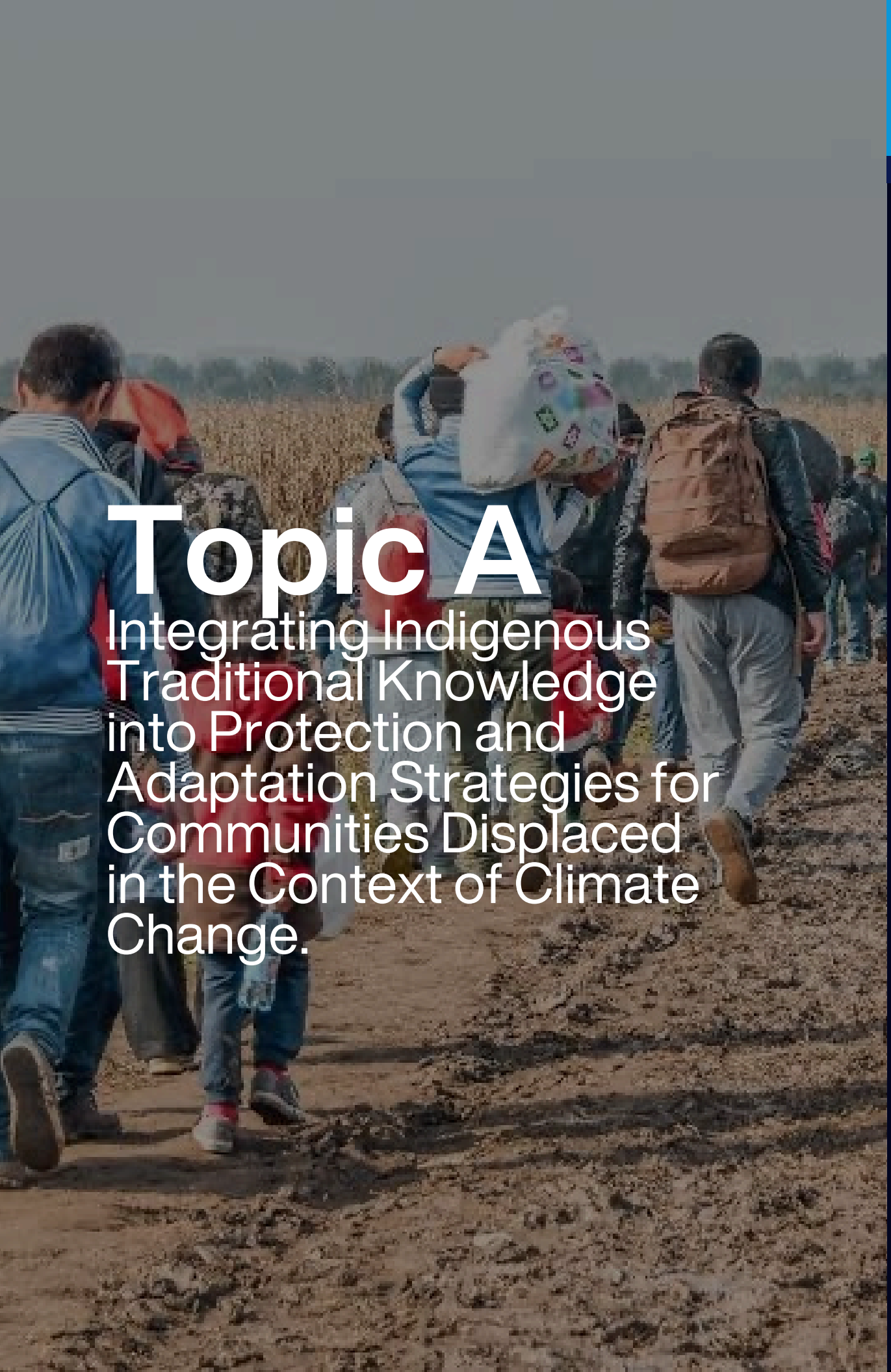
The United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, UNHCR, or UN Refugee agency was established in 1950 by the UN General Assembly after the Second World War, and it is guided by the 1951 Refugee Convention. Currently it operates across 122 countries and assists 129.4 million refugees. It is in charge of coordinating international action to protect refugees, forcibly displaced communities and stateless people by providing essential life- saving assistance like shelter, food, water, and medical care. The UNHCR also supports former refugees who have returned to their home country, people displaced within their own country, and individuals who are stateless or whose nationality is disputed.

In this framework of Sustainability and Indigenous Roots, UNHCR has implemented measures to safeguard refugees' cultures with sustainable solutions. Since climate change can increase the frequency of the disasters that affect people, UNHCR is looking to implement sustainable actions in their operations. These include providing supplies in recycled packaging, alignment with the UN Sustainable Development Goals, and implementing renewable energy for offices, infrastructure, and camps.

Regarding indigenous people, UNHCR looks to partner with global human rights bodies to preserve their cultural heritage and also looks to help them to get official papers such as birth certificates or identifications to help them stop being stateless. They also look to fund projects like language workshops, farming tools, and fishing gear to help local indigenous communities preserve their tradition and lifestyle. At the same time they help to provide translation services







Topic A

Integrating Indigenous Traditional Knowledge into Protection and Adaptation Strategies for Communities Displaced in the Context of Climate Change.

Guiding Question

To what extent should the physical design and resource management of sustainable displacement settlements

incorporate indigenous traditional knowledge to ensure both long-term environmental resilience and the preservation of cultural identity?

Indigenous Traditional Knowledge (ITK) are a set of practices and techniques that are refined and passed through generations in indigenous communities and are based on values like reciprocity and taking care of nature. This information is important because it is based on many years of observation and can be applied to a vast series of scenarios.

This topic focuses on using this knowledge to protect and help adapt communities forced to move because of climate change. This has become more relevant in recent years since weather and environmental disasters driven by climate change are constantly increasing, leaving millions of displaced people each year and affecting regions like the Amazon or Pacific Islands. Some regions face shortages in food, water and resources. Some organizations involved in this issue are the International Organization for Migration (IOM), the UN

Refugee Agency (UNHCR), the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), and the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC).





"I saw first-hand how climate change is devastating their lands, destroying their way of life, and threatening their very survival."
-António Guterres, Secretary General of the UN

Historical context

For a long time, international plans to combat climate change and handle disasters relied only on Western science and technology, ignoring the value of traditional knowledge from indigenous peoples. For generations, these communities have protected their territories and learned to adapt to nature's practices through sustainable practices. However, as climate change accelerated, thousands of people have been forced to leave their homes, putting both their lives and their cultures and ancestral wisdom at risk.

Important milestones, like the creation of the Local Communities and Indigenous Peoples Platform, helped shift the course toward greater inclusion. Today, the international community recognizes that protecting people displaced by the climate crisis requires more than just formal science, it needs to be combined with indigenous wisdom.

The recognition of this traditional knowledge in climate policy started gaining momentum in the early 2000s. Indigenous groups began demanding participation in the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), warning that forced displacement means losing not just a house, but also their connection to their history and identity.

Example of historical context

The climate-induced displacement of indigenous Andean communities in Peru and Bolivia illustrates the critical need for traditional knowledge, as early standardized humanitarian aid failed due to ignoring ancestral water management, prompting UNHCR to successfully integrate ancient techniques like raised- field farming (waru waru) to restore food security and climate adaptation.





Measures taken

Several international measures already address the integration of Indigenous and traditional knowledge into climate adaptation. In 2007, the United Nations General Assembly adopted Resolution A/RES/61/295, which contains the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP). It recognizes Indigenous peoples' rights to maintain, control, protect, and develop their traditional knowledge and cultural practices.

The Paris Agreement provides an international framework for adaptation. Article 7 recognizes that adaptation action should take into account, as appropriate, traditional knowledge, knowledge of Indigenous Peoples, and local knowledge systems. The Local Communities and Indigenous Peoples Platform (LCIPP), established under the UNFCCC, supports the exchange of knowledge and experiences and promotes the participation of Indigenous People and local communities in climate action. Governments have also included these approaches in their climate commitments. According to the UNFCCC's 2025 NDC Synthesis Report, 72% of Parties reported an increased focus on the role of Indigenous Peoples and local communities in climate adaptation and mitigation.

Despite this progress, implementation remains uneven. UNDRR identified the need for greater capacity development, stronger integration of Indigenous knowledge into science and technology, improved early warning systems, and better documentation and access to this knowledge. These limitations are relevant when developing adaptation and disaster risk reduction measures for communities facing climate related displacement.



"We must speed-up efforts to deliver climate justice and scale up finance and capacities for adaptation and loss and damage."
-António Guterres, Secretary General of the UN

Guiding Questions

1. Inwhat wayscan Indigenous Traditional Knowledge regarding sustainable water and land management be integrated into the design and operation of settlements?
2. What funding mechanisms and international grants can UNHCR establish to directly support indigenous adaptation projects rather than typical international government assistance aid?
3. How can UNHCR ensure that communication and emergency alert systems in displacement camps are provided in native languages to prevent misunderstandings?
4. What role should indigenous women play in designing community protection work, considering their acknowledged role as primary managers of natural resources and family relationship?
5. Which legal actions can be implemented to guarantee that displaced indigenous people retain their rights, knowledge and traditions when interacting with humanitarian partners?
6. How would emergency food relief programs transition from imported ratio distribution to supporting indigenous agroecological practices?
7. In what ways can Indigenous Traditional Knowledge be efficiently implemented into existing infrastructure and models of host countries?
8. Should educational programs in displacement settings incorporate native languages, oral histories, and traditional ecological practices into standard learning curricula?
9. What programs can be established within displacement sites to ensure elders can continue teaching oral traditions, Indigenous Traditional Knowledge, and ecological skills to younger generations?
10. Is there a way to ensure Indigenous Traditional Knowledge methods are preserved and made accessible in case of future reference?



Topic B

Sustainable Settlements and Resource Management for Forcibly Displaced Indigenous Communities.

Guiding Question

To what extent should sustainable settlements and resource management strategies incorporate Indigenous traditional knowledge and protect cultural identity while addressing the environmental challenges faced by forcibly displaced Indigenous communities?

Forcibly displaced Indigenous communities face a complex combination of displacement, loss of land, limited access to resources, environmental risks, and threats to cultural continuity. Displacement may result from armed conflict, persecution, development projects, environmental degradation, or disasters. For Indigenous People, displacement can have consequences because land and natural resources are closely connected to cultural identity, livelihoods, governance, and traditional knowledge. The International Labour Organization's Convention No. 169 recognizes Indigenous and tribal peoples' rights to land and natural resources and emphasizes their participation in decisions affecting their communities.

Forced displacement is still an international issue. According to UNHCR, 117.8 million people were forcibly displaced worldwide at the end of 2025. Climate change can make these situations more difficult because of floods, droughts, storms and other disasters can damage homes and sources of income can increase pressure on water and land resources.

For this reason, creating sustainable settlements is not only about providing temporary houses. Also means ensuring access to clean water, sanitation, healthcare, education and natural resources. At the same time these settlements should respect indigenous cultures and allow communities to participate in decisions about their future. UNHCR promotes approaches that consider both displaced people and host communities while also taking environmental sustainability and climate adaptation into account.





"A well-designed settlement balances the immediate and long-term needs of the displaced population and their host communities."
-UNHCR

Historical context

The displacement of indigenous people has historical roots in colonization, forced relocation, resource extraction and land appropriation. For many years, indigenous communities had limited access to participate in decisions involved into their territories and natural resources. International recognition of their rights developed gradually during the 20th century.

An important step was the adoption of ILO Convention No. 107 (1957) established standards regarding indigenous and tribal people, including their rights to land, natural resources, consultation and participation. In 1989, ILO Convention No.169 strengthened these protections and recognized the importance of Indigenous people´s participation in decisions affecting their lives and territories. In 2007, the United Nations General Assembly adopted the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous People (UNDRIP), which recognized Indigenous people´s rights to their lands, territories and resources and protection against forced removal. These developments established stronger international standards for protecting Indigenous communities and their relationship with their territories.

More recently, international humanitarian efforts have increasingly addressed the conditions of forcibly displaced people and the sustainability of their settlements. UNHCR promotes settlement planning that considers access to water, sanitation, livelihoods, environmental protection and climate related risks, while involving displaced and host communities in planning. However, displacement can increase pressure on land and natural resources, creating challenges for both displaced Indigenous communities and their hosts.

Example of historical context

The displacement of Indigenous peoples through colonization and land appropriation led to stronger international protections, including ILO Convention No. 169 (1989) and the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (2007), which recognize their rights to their lands, resources, and participation in decisions affecting their communities.





Measures taken

The international community has established several measures to address the rights and protections of Indigenous Peoples affected by forced displacement. One of the most relevant instruments is the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP) adopted in 2007, which recognizes Indigenous Peoples' rights to self-determination, traditional lands, natural resources, and the preservation of their cultural identities. Articles 10, 21, and 26 are the most important, as they address forced relocation, socio-economic conditions, and Indigenous Peoples' rights to their lands and territories.

Despite these international frameworks and pilot integration programs, significant execution barriers persist. Host nations frequently lack legal mechanisms to recognize customary land tenure, leaving displaced Indigenous populations without land security or political representation. Furthermore, international aid mechanisms predominantly prioritize short-term humanitarian assistance over long-term, culturally tailored infrastructure and local governance systems. Consequently, existing measures remain largely non-binding, leaving many displaced communities in precarious settlements with inadequate access to natural resources and limited self- sufficiency.





"Settlement planning should consider the needs of displaced people and host communities, while promoting environmental sustainability and access to essential services."
-UNHCR

Guiding Questions

1. HowcanUNHCRcollaborate directly with indigenous community leaders to identify climate vulnerabilities and risks before forced displacement?
2. What legal gaps exist in international frameworks to protect the cultural and territorial rights of indigenous people due to climate disasters?
3. Should community-led waste management systems be implemented to prevent plastic and organic pollution from destroying local rivers and ecosystems?
4. Which renewable energy sources are best suited for remote settlements to replace fossil fuels, considering the resources of host countries and culture of indigenous communities?
5. Which conflict resolution mechanisms can be implemented between host communities and displaced indigenous populations to manage shared resources like fertile land, water and raw materials?
6. What steps should be taken to ensure that sanitation facilities inside indigenous communities prevent soil and water contamination?
7. How can renewable energy projects be safely installed in indigenous settlements without insulting or disrupting sacred lands or altering significantly the local landscape?
8. Which financial or logistical support can the international community provide to local municipalities so they do not absorb the consequences and cost of housing a large amount of displaced population?
9. Should it be guaranteed that indigenous elders and traditional authorities have power in deciding how internal resources are distributed?
10. How can settlements be designed to prevent ecological degradation forms like groundwater depletion, deforestation?

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